HERE LIES TROUBLE

Fourth draft

October 26, 2026

EXT. RUNYON CANYON -- LOS ANGELES

SPEAKER 1
Finally! We’re all together for our debrief on Here Lies Love. And – for whatever reason– we had to double book as exercise so of course we’re in Runyon Canyon, before 10am, after 8am. Our usual, and the best chance to catch some celebrities working out!

SPEAKER 2
I consent to that. Hell yes to seeing celebrities on the down low in short shorts. Yay! Now, can we get back to Here Lies Love already: first, let me say I love my friends who were in the show….

SPEAKER 3
Yeah. We love your friends who are in the show, yeah, the fault lies elsewhere. Those friends didn't write it, for instance….

SPEAKER 4
But like I said before, Filipino performers deserve so much better. They deserve a lot more.

SPEAKER 1
Okay, since we're just gonna spill the tea on the LA production of the Here Lies Love: why was there even a drag queen in that show? WTF were they saying about drag?

SPEAKER 3
Compare that character a la cabaret,

SPEAKER 2
.... wait... what was the impetus to change from a DJ to a drag queen? What have you heard? So you saw it on Broadway? Or no?

SPEAKER 3
No, we saw it here at Mark Taper in LA.

SPEAKER 2
Okay, so there's nothing to compare to, yeah. So did you see it on Broadway? No, okay, I've just heard all about, yeah, a lot of it, yeah, not all about. So in the NY production, that character is a deejay, okay, who just is on stage the whole time deejaying the show and acts as the announcer or a narrator, like a MC. So they changed that to a drag queen for the West Coast staging. They changed it. They added it; it wasn't always a drag queen, okay? That character was a deejay.

SPEAKER 4
Yeah. Never a drag queen, got it.

SPEAKER 4
Just a male DJ, and they were just in the booth the whole time, right? Yeah, he just did the show announcing on a microphone.

SPEAKER 2
Didn't go out onto the stage, didn't—okay. So that was something new that the director wanted as well, because he's homosexual, yeah, and be, I think he, he wanted,

SPEAKER 3
you mean, the director, the LA director,

SPEAKER 2
and he wanted that character, allegedly, to be more active, okay, versus having to stay at the Dee Jay booth, get away from that lame staging, right? He's like, and we're not gonna have live deejaying, since this person's just gonna fake like, I don't know, I don't want to fake the deejay part. I guess, okay, trying to change this around to show that in concept could be a good idea....

SPEAKER 2
This drag character can parody somebody with love at the beginning, but then kind of reject, kind of reject it, yeah, yeah. Later in the storyline, when you take it all off and you're like, when she said, You used to love me, yeah? Where was that love later—he wanted it to be like that love was so apparent in the beginning, and then you strip it away, because you can learn to not love someone, yeah, even after you idolize them at the beginning.

SPEAKER 3
Deep. So is it about Imelda or Phantom of the Opera? What are they doing with that character?

SPEAKER 2
They did what they could with the script. I mean, there's no way around it that this musical is glorifying the Marcos regime

SPEAKER 4
yeah, even though they keep saying so much that it's not, it's 100% glorifying Imelda and whitewashing Marcos

SPEAKER 2
Yeah, yeah, we would think like 90, 90% of it was Marcos love, right? Yeah, it was like,

SPEAKER 3
... it takes such a sad turn when it starts with that small bit about Ninoy Aquino, right? Then a really bad song enters,

SPEAKER 2
and we just barely meet him in the beginning. Yeah, is this even historically accurate, about dating Aquino? Can somebody quickly check it on their phone?

SPEAKER 3
We don't really know. And then it's about this broken love story, right, between

SPEAKER 4
Ninoy and Imelda—thank you, yes, they did date—

SPEAKER 3
and then it goes away. And then it's just a scene with a sad costume and then boom end of Marcos. It's all sad, sad funeral, sad colors, bad music.

SPEAKER 3
She was like the queen of shoes. Can we talk about Imelda's shoes?

SPEAKER 1
to say she wore shoes like those flats in the play, we all are like the shoes, the shoes, the rooms of shoes… no trainers no flats

SPEAKER 3
.... right, the shoes and those whatever those last ones were, from where and literally beige, chunky heel, beige chunky, the most boring pumps ever like Payless pumps, yeah, two, bedazzled or flats, slingback flats, which Imelda would never wear those, I mean, and never wear the Payless pumps either, but maybe when she was poor. But then there was a scene with a cocaine party in a disco in New York, with the glitter ball and the cocaine and the fake Bob Fosse choreography, which I hated, because I'm like, Fosse plus Imelda, no, right, right nothing can make that right, but in that one cocaine scene, she had real shoes on, real heels that we were sold on. And I was like, Where are these shoes for the rest of this play? Girl came to play

SPEAKER 1
And I'm just gonna impose a note of historical fact here in that we have been to Tacloban, and we have seen the Imelda Museum in Tacloban, which includes a small part of the notorious shoe collection

SPEAKER 3
at her, yeah, she built this house; she has this whole compound built with all the money she stole, where she stored all her crazy "I am the mother of the Earth" paintings and other looted art and furniture slowly decaying in a moderately air-conditioned room, and a small room of all her shoes, but really only some of the shoes, yeah, just a token amount. I mean, nobody has all the shoes, yeah. WHERE ARE ALL THE SHOES?? I mean, these are the original Epstein files, am I right? So we feel like, you know, not so much research into Imelda went on here; it's obvious just from the footwear, but just seeing Imelda's shrine in Tacloban, and also watching the Ramona Diaz documentary about Imelda from 2003, which the production crew of the LA production have not watched. Such a big miss. It doesn't even honor the super crazy that really is Imelda. Her essential self is a loco muthafucka. She's so much crazier than she is in this play. I mean, aside from the Disney princess-ification of her? Yeah, it's also like, you don't even know this woman. She's a being astraling traveling outside of the solar system. Yeah? Her concepts of reality are so batshit bonkers, I'm talking crazy town banana pants. She is a very entertaining person, yeah, but not in this way that's supposed to be relatable. Let's be real, I hate Ferdinand Marcos, he betrayed me.

SPEAKER 4
that moment of like, I was cheated on, let me go, instead I go oppress a bunch of people right now.

SPEAKER 1
When we know that the historically accurate thing for Filipino women
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
in the Philippines to do after they have been cheated on is to get a dance instructor, right, or a mobile phone instructor --oye poppy those new phones are SO COMPLICATED-- so find anything to learn, as long as the instructor is hot hot hot.

SPEAKER 2
any kind of interior designer, hot man, yeah, yeah, or say you want to scuba dive, that’s a good one

SPEAKER 3
also a good dresser, yeah. I mean it also is like, I think it's really clear from Imelda—whatever—from the way Imelda tells the story, even though she doesn't tell it this way, you can just know that Imelda picked him and built his career, that she was like, I am going to get to the top through this man, yeah, and I'm gonna do everything it takes to kind of stage and dramaturg this performance. And then, you know the title of the play, Here Lies Love, is what she put on his headstone. It's his gravestone. And she tells this romantic tale of how, this is my great love lost, and so that's why I put it on his headstone: Here Lies Love. There is my love. So it's like it defeats Imelda's own performance of the great love story, historically, you know, please. That's Imelda's Here Lies Love: a tombstone. But the play Here Lies Love doesn't even allude to her internal-narrative of this incredible lifelong romance.

SPEAKER 4
How much do you know about the gay connection?

SPEAKER 3
Oh, yeah, nothing. But I feel like a lot can be inferred.

SPEAKER 1
But I would love to go there, before we get to that, can I just say one other note directly from Makati, from one of the fabulous Filipino supermodels, and the scuttlebutt in Makati, it's her daughter Imee Marcos that is big in gay circles, and they use the words fag hag directly. I mean, okay, so Imee is well known for this, so I feel like there's a confusion about the sister and mother, the daughter and the mother in this depiction about what's what. Anyway, sorry to interrupt. Please go ahead. It's the daughter.

SPEAKER 4
Yeah. So what's his name? The guy that wrote it

SPEAKER 4
David Byrne, yes.

SPEAKER 4
So he just didn't know who she was, but found this picture of her in a club, and was like, this woman looks fabulous. Studio 54. Disco. Party. And then did just the smallest, most mild whiff of research, which I don't understand how you miss in any research about her, right? But getting the whole thing wrong? Just imagining this part of Philippine history?

SPEAKER 4
They just thought she was fabulous. Let's make this fabulous musical, right? And then wrote it. Brought in Fat Boy Slim to write jaunty music to it. They both wrote it, yeah. And then they brought in a Filipino consultant, who, I think was somebody's mom, who was like, hmmm: Do you know this was a dictator? And they're like, no, oh, so

SPEAKER 3
Do we know that somebody's mom worked on this play?

SPEAKER 1
That's why she was one of the producers. She is a famous Filipino-American producer, what’s her name?

SPEAKER 2
Yeah. So no changes but on opening night, a statement was read on opening night. And it was essentially: welcome. The reason that we did this play was because LA is the biggest Filipino diaspora in the nation. And we hope that this piece is a conversation starter. It is by no means meant to glorify the happenings, but it's a conversation starter of how we got here. And I hope you enjoy and continue talking about this show. It was like they were apologizing for the show. She was apologizing for the show before it even started!

SPEAKER 1
because she knew the context in LA, where all the Filipinos fled Marcos, fuck that guy

SPEAKER 2
yeah. As if: you're not gonna like this, but think of it as how we talk about it. So that's where the problem lies. It should be called: Here lies the problem.

SPEAKER 4
And the LA formulation of the play was basically a rip off of the play Les Miserables, they don't even mention the people that are being oppressed, right? The oppressors aren't even mentioned, let alone getting musical numbers, let alone post-Marcos being the main character in the whole fucking story, right, right? You know, I don't want to see how Imelda had a horrible childhood.

SPEAKER 1
We were talking about Sophia Coppola's depiction of Marie Antoinette as a possible analog, where it was all soft lens, obsessions about what cakes can I eat, and what dresses am I wearing? And about the vibe, the scene and not about political realities and you're gonna get your head lopped off.

SPEAKER 2
See ya! I don't believe in glorifying Marie Antoinette.

SPEAKER 3
But there's something really ballsy about a play that really asks an audience of Filipino-Americans to be a fan of Imelda Marcos for quite a lot of the play, yeah. And what are we to make of the fact that the audience loved it and ate it all up?

SPEAKER 2
So what was the difference between being there on opening night versus being there on a later date? We went during the closing week. When did you go?

SPEAKER 3
Yeah, when? So there were a lot of Filipino people in the opening-night audience, yeah, when? That moment when the drag version introduced Imelda, there were audible boos, oh, and no cheers, oh, on opening night, yeah. And the drag queen was like,

SPEAKER 2
We saw it. We booed and people looked at us, yeah, yeah. And we're like, Oh, you don't know,

SPEAKER 3
and so for almost all, I mean, for the whole play, I never applauded Imelda or Marcos or the bad government, but I applauded Pinoy Kino songs and the revolution
(MORE)

SPEAKER 3 (CONT'D)
songs, even though they were the worst songs and clearly written after the fact. But everybody else loved all those songs, and there were tons of Filipinos in the audience. People were coming with, you know, like eight people from their family, yeah? Or their three best girlfriends, or whatever. There were all kinds of selfies being done beforehand. And then everybody moves in together. Merch was being sold, yeah. And then everybody's like, yay. The whole time, hooray, yay. Good, good number. I like the dancing, everybody in the whole theater was and then it ended, and then everybody gave standing ovations. And the only time there was any sentiment of a political, a political sentiment in the audience was at the very, very end, the last thing projected is that Imelda's son is now present in the Philippines. And then people were like, oh, it was a surprise, yeah.

SPEAKER 2
It was definitely behind me. The first time I saw it. She—that last, that last projection, yeah—she goes what the fuck?

SPEAKER 3
Are we talking about the Filipinas we know now? I know one now who lives in happily Bay, and she and I have talked, over the years, many times about her fandom for Imelda. And the last time we talked about this, which was recently, I was like, GIRL, you got to drop the Imelda fandom. Yeah. It's NOT okay. And especially now you can see that kind of corruption in the USA, with Trump gilded properties and Ivanka and Melania. You have to willfully not see how bad it is to be a fan of Imelda. And she said, Well, you know, growing up, there
(MORE)

SPEAKER 3 (CONT'D)
just wasn't any other Filipino person to be a fan of, and Imelda is like this glamorous whole hand. And I really think many Filipino and Filipino American people only relate to Filipino culture and history in these very surface ways, right? Where it's not real history. It's just like, well, this person's famous and this person's famous and this person's famous, and one of them is a fucking dictator, but they're all just celebrities.

SPEAKER 4
people are so confused. The way characters are shown on stages and screens does not help. In the musical, The Wedding Singer, there always has to be a Filipino woman in the cast, because there's a character that's an Imelda impersonation. And I'm like, Why the hell is this the character? Yeah, then that also means that you can't cast any other Filipinos in the production, if you have more than one Filipino person no no no, that's the only part they can have. Which drives me crazy.

SPEAKER 2
That's her status in the 1980s. That's why wedding singers, like a Filipino wedding singer, were the thing.

SPEAKER 1
OK for the actual theater people and stage nerds here, I have a question. There was a very high percentage of the time in Here Lies Love where there was music. But it wasn't really a musical as much as it was a soundtrack,

SPEAKER 4
and the story was told through them like music videos, augmented by telling you what happened in the story with text on projection. Take for example that part where he went to America,

SPEAKER 1
that was more like a libretto; a libretto would be projected like that, but not a play—more like an opera or a silent film, inner title, right?

SPEAKER 2
Because this narration was not in the script, yeah, this production made a specific choice to do that, right?

SPEAKER 3
right, right? I mean, it's clear this production really has tried to rescue this point. They tried. It is really clear. Could they not? Could they have found or written a better song than "When I grow up, I want to be a drummer oh yeah, oh yeah." I mean, really, but,

SPEAKER 4
I personally didn't like a single song in the show; a couple get stuck in my head, but not because I like them, because my head, my brain is making fun of how bad they are.

SPEAKER 3
And also, I mean, to have no Cory, no Corazon Aquino, and I know Cory is a gesture too, but really, it's like, to me, the obvious move would have been to—this is a character—turn it into a Korean Kino musical, if you really want to rescue it. Yeah. But even after Nino dies, it's like, then they take away that actress's yellow dress, and put her in that horrible, boring uniform and that colorless, like concentration camp uniform, and then, you know, just have the outside.

SPEAKER 2
And those are, like, they were so proud of this custom, you know, right?

SPEAKER 1
I mean, the costumes themselves were pretty cool, I thought, I mean, the actual fashion I was liking,

SPEAKER 2
Too American

SPEAKER 3
I don't, yes, I don't care how American Filipino American people are. But I think the spoon or not spoon is a key indicator when eating and especially when eating in public at a restaurant. My sister, when she became a McKinsey consultant after college, you know, didn't order spoons. Didn't ask for spoons at fancy restaurants with clients. And so she was just trying to eat with a fork. And so then she realized she was pushing food into her fork with her hand, and she had to stop trying to make the spoon, make the fork into the spoon.

SPEAKER 4
Wow, I'm leaning more into eating with the spoon, because that gets so much more of the sauce content, which, for me, is the most important part of the food

SPEAKER 3
food is just the vehicle for sauce, right, right, right. Indeed, indo people, Indonesians, always give you a spoon. They have a spoon thing too. Oh, they do, yeah. I feel like whenever the Polynesian thing was in that part of the world, everybody decided on the spoon. I mean, first your hands. If you can use your hands, that's the first choice. But then if you need to use a spoon.

SPEAKER 1
Wait: can we talk about another thing in the LA production? Did people get up and dance in the middle? Because we are very leery
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
about forced audience participation. If we're expected to do audience interaction dance, hard pass.

SPEAKER 3
Well in New York, the Broadway version, you were standing the whole time, I think, right, yes,

SPEAKER 2
if you didn't have the seats in the balcony, the only other seat was on the floor, and that was like a dance pit, and it was like an open concept stage with platforms that moved on and off and around.

SPEAKER 4
Imagine standing in a club situation while that funeral is happening, right?

SPEAKER 3
But they didn't have that, I bet, in the Broadway version, I bet the Broadway version didn't have any of the Ninoy Aquino stuff.

SPEAKER 4
It did because that song, drummer song, the fucking drummer song

SPEAKER 2
what's up with the way Imelda was played? Was that a NY thing?

SPEAKER 3
Maybe the NY actress half-originated it with Lea Salonga? Oh yeah, Lea Salonga played it sometimes. They gave Leo Salonga that dumb song, yeah, oh yeah, oh yeah. My God, that really makes me sad. Where were your seats for that number? We were stage left? We were pretty far over.

SPEAKER 1
No, we were closer to the center. We just didn't get any glitter, so
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
we were far, okay, but just outside the glitter red drop

SPEAKER 4
so one thing about the staging, I love a thrust; that's my favorite kind of theater. And this was the worst staging I have ever seen in a dress. The entire time she was downstage center, all the way far, and so we just got her back.

SPEAKER 3
I also thought the set was awful. What drugs were the fucking scenic design instructors doing when they made those sets? I know, right? It's so boring.

SPEAKER 4
So there's a stage back there that was just blocked off. It's not just up in the center. They just decided to just use that thrust part and block off pretty much the whole stage. And then, those weird bleacher things that moved were curved inward,

SPEAKER 1
It was just for one visual effect, because they wanted it to be a semi circle that opened,

SPEAKER 4
I understand the geometric, conceptual, sculptural parts of that idea, but as a practical matter on the real-world stage when Imelda would go sit in the middle, and they would sit behind her, if you were on the side, you got no one, not a single line of sight; you only got backs. The thing about a thrust is that you got backs, yeah? And the thing that's weird, and the thing about a thrust is that usually you will get a back or two, yeah. And the goal is that everyone has one person that's important, right? And so maybe you're getting one person's back in the conversation,
(MORE)

SPEAKER 4 (CONT'D)
and you're seeing one person's friend. So it's always a little different, no matter where you sit, right? We didn't get a really good line of sight on anybody. Nothing. Nothing was ever like, I see it. Sometimes I don't even know if an actor is wearing makeup, right?

SPEAKER 2
Oh my gosh. I had to hold my tongue so hard when I heard somebody say: I love the music and the set is amazing.

SPEAKER 4
Ugh. Those columns that had the disco balls inside, yeah, the Filipino,

SPEAKER 2
woven pattern that's on the peacock chairs, yeah, yeah.

SPEAKER 4
But it was only because it was that close to us that I saw that, right? And once you got like, two feet away, you couldn't tell, right?

SPEAKER 3
Wait, was there a shoe pattern in the tile? A heel that's upside down did not even the tile pattern? AGAIN ABOUT THE SHOES. But it doesn't matter if you don't put shoes on the performer. Those are the shoes that people will remember?

SPEAKER 2
So I had heard this not from her, but from my other friend. I had lunch with her the closing week, and she was like, because I was like, can we talk about the shoes? And she was in the show, in the beginning, and then yeah, and she, she was like, oh yeah. In rehearsal, the actress who played Imelda, she leaned over to me and
(MORE)

SPEAKER 2 (CONT'D)
she says, can you be honest with me? These shoes are horrible.

SPEAKER 1
My shoes, all of my shoes in this show are terrible, right?

SPEAKER 3
Mostly, I just want to make a sitcom where that interaction happens. I just want two Filipina actresses at rehearsal talking about one of them playing Imelda in horrible shoes.

SPEAKER 1
excellent. Wow, so you didn't like the fashion either, Barong Filipino like that that they went the, the flag?

SPEAKER 2
yeah, they're cool. I just wasn't sure they worked in the play.

SPEAKER 3
Me too. It wasn't a revolution that had a uniform. That was exactly the point of the people power. Well, it was a revolution; it wasn't a war.

SPEAKER 1
They didn't have a uniform, but they had a color. And that color was nowhere in sight.

SPEAKER 3
It was just indicated on a shadow figure a couple times, two times when she appeared; she was that yellow, bright Corey Aquino yellow.

SPEAKER 1
And I had to find that out from Instagram; I had to find that out from a rando Instagram account after the show. Because I was like, there has to be something

SPEAKER 4
We see the Doc Martins boots that were yellow too. Yeah, yeah, which I want really bad, really.

SPEAKER 3
What a strange ass show. Because it opens with a Disney princess number. You know: I'm poor, but I'm pretty. Here's my best friend, slash Yaya, and we're dancing. I'm dancing around in the sheets. She's trying to fold the sheets. I mean, what the fuck is this? What are we? And then people are clapping. I'm thinking what is even happening. We are ... we're imagining poor Imelda as this pretty, pretty princess. And then, what's next? We're hoping she gets married!

SPEAKER 4
Her entrance should have been dark and scary, and she walks out with moody shadows. I WANT TO SUCK YOUR BLOOD.

SPEAKER 3
hahah. Okay, let's do that as an AU fanfic version. Because I didn't know. I mean, the Grimaldas family of Leyte is a very wealthy family, and now they are the fucking biggest ballers of the Philippines because of Imelda.

SPEAKER 1
The Marcos crime family expropriated a lot of money from that country and/or from USA aid to that country, and also took a cut of all business deals in the country; it was all of them. They put it in gold bars and they pretended it was historical pre-colonial gold, that they found Yamashita's Gold, you know what I mean. The Filipino folktale about finding buried treasure. But it was really expropriating OUR money! THEFT.

SPEAKER 3
And Imelda gave it all to her family, yeah. But even though I had always thought the Remaldas family was so wealthy, it does turn out—after I saw Here Lies Love, I looked it up—that Imelda did belong to the poor branch, or whatever, the poorer branch of this rich family. So she had money until she was eight, and then her mother died, and then she had to go live, whatever Imelda says, in a shack. But we don't know what that means. They did say nipa hut.

SPEAKER 1
Are you kidding?

SPEAKER 3
In the real world this is a story where Imelda is the villain. It is a villainous creation story; that is not a love story. It is not a story where she grew up as some nobody from the block, where she was not the center, the non-center, not something marginal but instead part of this huge wealth. This story is not a love story where she loses everything to love.

SPEAKER 1
And of course, that person, that narcissist, having to grow up poor or whatever, is plotting her revenge on the world from eight years old, and when she's like 17 years old, she's like, that's a handsome politician who is coming closer and closer to my web. I am, we know where we're going with this. We're gonna do, you know? I mean, she is, like, I read magazines with fucking JFK Jr, with JFK and Jackie in them. I know, I know what to do next, and she did it, and then she dismantled the rule of law and established a level of corruption in the country that the country's never recovered from. And that's the part I'm like, where is Here
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
Lies Love? Where is the part about the corruption? Where is the part about the rule of law? No more laws, the Constitution is gone. Every bit of law and order has been dismantled in this country. Why is that story not part of this play?

SPEAKER 2
The play explained, well, no, it didn't explain. It mentioned that the people were mad at her for some reason, right? The people are mad. And they mentioned some stuff at one point, yeah.

SPEAKER 1
And that's really all we did. That's it. And the thing is that they said, how many people were killed, but it's not in the auditorium, in the projection, but it's not just about how many people die. That makes for an evil government. If you look at how many people this federal administration is killing every day, it's not so many Americans that they are killing every day. It's not just about that. It's about what they are doing to the Constitution, the structure. Yeah, it's like, how do your institutions work? How do people get to go to school or get to make money, or get to have peaceful lives, or whatever? Can they just have those things? Or do they have to constantly be bribing the next round of officials and the next round of officials? And is that because the person at the top is always demanding this level of bribery? It's like, where is that story? Which is the only story? That's the only story of the Marcos regime.

SPEAKER 3
It's gone. It's not there. You have to, you have to read, you have to read the drama journeys,

SPEAKER 2
The best part of the entire experience of going to see that was that big poster outside the theater

SPEAKER 4
that was about the historical context, yeah, that's what they did, tried to bolt on historical context

SPEAKER 2
Yeah, that part was good, yeah? Because our friend that went to see it with us, I don't know her too well, but she was pretty excited, because she doesn't really know the context of this story about Imelda, because my family literally will not talk about it, right, right? They're like, we don't talk about it. We don't want to, right? We'll not talk about it. And then she's like, I didn't really do a lot of my own research, because, you know, she was a child, right? So, she says I kind of want to know. And then afterwards she's like, Yeah, I don't really know that much about this, right?

SPEAKER 1
Yeah. It's what you said. All of a sudden people got mad at her. Yeah, and the drag queen said, I don't like you as much anymore. I'm not gonna be so fabulous around you. I mean, that's my protest. Did this poor drag queen have to give up drag because, you know, that also doesn't seem right. Why doesn't she just start dressing somebody else? You know what? What's the lesson here? It's oh, now I'm political. I stopped doing drag. That's the wrong lesson, right? And that actually kind of seems very Filipino though. It's oh, gender normativity is the lesson, and now we wear all these boring Catholic school girl uniforms. This isn't
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
what actually happened, and it's nothing to valorize.

SPEAKER 4
Now, if you can imagine, and this was a directorial choice changed from Broadway and other previous productions, the show used to end with a mega mix of all Imelda songs,

SPEAKER 1
really, you mean her actually singing

SPEAKER 4
first, she would sing all the songs again, right?

SPEAKER 1
It would end in here lies love? It would end in a big Dance party, and they're partying. Her in the middle, yeah? Just her spinning around, right?

SPEAKER 4
and the west coast director's like, we're not doing that.

SPEAKER 1
Yeah, yeah. Are you saying that on the Broadway version there was the stuff about Ninoy Keenan? There was the part where he died. There was the boring song that late poor Lea Salonga had to sing, as well as the boring costume, right, that horrible song, and then they had the mega mix with the dance party. So a dim political assassination, people power revolution, dictators deposed Mega Man, even more dance party, even more fun. That is

SPEAKER 2
really, really fucked up. Are

SPEAKER 1
Are you kidding me? That's like, Hitler in springtime, yeah. Do you know that

SPEAKER 2
just ended with that? And they're like, end of show,

SPEAKER 1
yeah, yeah. There is a lot about here, life's love that I was thinking about Hitler and springtime kind of a lot, where I'm like, what it is, yeah, because it's a joke. Right? In the world of the producers, they're trying to make a horribly offensive show that will fail, and they accidentally make a show that's usually popular, yeah? And just sitting there, not clapping and then, but imagining that Megamix thing with people being like, yeah.

SPEAKER 2
It almost seems purposeful, like we're gonna do a show that glorifies Imelda and we're gonna put her in terrible shoes. There's no way this is gonna be good.

SPEAKER 1
It's really weird. The only theory that works is a conspiracy theory.

SPEAKER 4
Tell me something. Oh, something interesting on that is that Mamma Mia was a big show on Broadway because it became a show in London, in London because it was associated with bridal parties. And so they were really bachelorette parties that went to Mamma Mia,

SPEAKER 1
yeah, cabaret theater, yeah, exactly: get drunk, yeah, put on the veil and sing the whole time, yeah.

SPEAKER 4
So with the disco stuff in New York, and here's, Here Lies Love, was this kind of gay, gay disco, party theater thing, or what was there make it,

SPEAKER 2
It wasn't very gay, okay.

SPEAKER 1
I mean, there wasn't even drug use, so was it? No, no.

SPEAKER 2
So it wasn't very gay, okay, even though they really missed that. But it's also because the writer didn't—I don't think—understand gay, okay? And when Fat Boy Slim was like, we'll write music. I don't care, whatever, right? I think they were totally checked out of any critical context. We'll just send you music for whatever lyrics you send us. We don't care, yeah, pay us and we'll send you some tracks, yeah?

SPEAKER 1
But also, I'm like, I don't want to necessarily see the story of a drag queen who used to be a big Imelda fan. Drag can also be critical. Drag can be parody and it can be like, fuck this person.

SPEAKER 2
Yeah, fuck this person

SPEAKER 1
Look at Laura Benal. I mean, there are so many other drag performers, history is full of drag. History has just as much of this kind of drag as fandom drag. It's like anti fandom drag or phantom drag, right? And so, why take us on this journey of this apolitical or fascist drag queen? It's like those are the only positions of that drag queen. Either they know nothing, they're just ignorant, or they're fascist, and then they go on this journey, and then they repudiate their phantom object, and then they take off their drag. I'm like, what are we saying? What are we promoting? What is the character? What is that character? Yeah, if you think about the MC of
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
Cabaret, that character who also just frames the story, or whatever, does kind of go on a journey, and it's not this journey, though, you can kind of sketch out a political journey that isn't whatever that was. So odd, so strange, any of these choices. I'm just like, who was, who was watching? The real story is when this choice was made, who was saying, this is okay, yeah, let's do it this way.

SPEAKER 2
This mythical mother producer, I think she was trying to salvage whatever she could. I think she was like, well, this show is gonna happen without with her, yeah,

SPEAKER 3
David Byrne and Fat Boy Slim.

SPEAKER 1
Well, you know what? I have some good news for everyone on this walk, which is that we had nothing to do with this show, and we should be really proud of that. Yes, this is the kind of show where, at the end of it, you should just be glad nobody wrote you in in any way.

SPEAKER 4
Well, when, I mean, when I had lunch with my friend, I did tell her, because, you know, I auditioned for the show. Oh yeah, I remember that.

SPEAKER 2
Oh Hollywood.

SPEAKER 4
And I said, they say they protected you by not putting you in. And I said, really, I'm really proud of you.

SPEAKER 2
All. You're all so talented.

SPEAKER 3
But not once did I ever during the show think, God, I wish I was up there.

SPEAKER 1
Can you imagine having to do those stupid dances? I'm part of a demented entourage, oh my god,

SPEAKER 3
OMG

SPEAKER 2
that dance with the stupid little faces, like papers in front of the face, and the masks were just as bad.

SPEAKER 3
Oh, that also is a number that looks good from the front, but they brought the door out. So where we were sitting, we could see them lined up. They brought the door out past us, and then we saw them all line up behind the doors; the whole time I was thinking oh no, are you kidding me? Are you kidding?

SPEAKER 2
And there's a whole stage that they're just not using, yeah, not to use it and kind of do theater in the round, yeah, but never stage it for the round at all.

SPEAKER 4
The only thing that kind of helped for us, it was good for us, was whenever they were up on those little platforms, yeah, yeah, oh, yeah, yeah,

SPEAKER 2
we couldn't even read the projection, because the projection was on a bump. It curved towards us so I could read half of the foot sentences,

SPEAKER 4
Oh, no. And I was wondering, because it wasn't symmetrical. So I was like, there was some construction of the real stage with this bow proscenium, right?

SPEAKER 1
Because the whole conception for this show was those lunchtime performances on Filipino TV variety shows like these. Filipino variety shows have these lunchtime things where it's just like an hour of straight singing and dancing. It's like, boom, boom, boom, boom, you know, just a bunch of random ass shit. And so that was what he was thinking of for the design, right? It's like, have you been in the Philippines? It's like, do you know, Filipinos don't even know what gray or beige are

SPEAKER 2
It looked like primer. It was gonna get painted. It looked like Prime Minister or an English show where they have no natural sunlight

SPEAKER 4
Right? Yeah, it did look like a primer coat. Did they forget to paint it?

SPEAKER 1
No, if it was bright, I would be like, oh, and Imelda. And Imelda's shoes looked like rehearsal shoes. Well, these aren't the real shoes, but just to save your feet the first time, in these bad pumps for me, in the fat Yeah,

SPEAKER 4
in that chunky heel, yeah, she doesn't have money yet.

SPEAKER 1
right, right, yeah, that was an artistic choice. She kept coming out in that; they were her wedding shoes. I mean, barkles got married
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
in shoes like that. I will eat those because she did it, yeah? She just didn't, and we have pictures. I mean, also it's like they failed to understand her as a human; she should have been like a monster with light up shoes, yeah?

SPEAKER 4
really good. Oh, I know even more they're historical people. It's a real event, historical people. And not a lunchtime TV variety show.

SPEAKER 2
Parade them around, when they would enter, they projected a picture of them. We talked about this before....

SPEAKER 4
oh, oh yeah, yeah, the actual person. And then the actors dress her with nothing in the reference photo, nothing, and they projected a picture of Imelda's wedding, yeah, and it looked nothing like what she was wearing, right? On a stage your own, right? Just take it. Just take the picture and dress like it.

SPEAKER 2
Yeah? In Parade, someone comes out with very distinct facial hair, yeah? And then someone's not just clean shaven or just wearing a beard, right? It was like, This person had mutton chop. You don't show us that, right? We don't see that? And then the worst thing about that, though, was they had all the real people's pictures of all the white people. So when the black characters came out, they just projected a black man, and then they're not the actual character.

SPEAKER 1
Just, here's any black man, wow. Man, wow. They just showed a random black man, yes. So what
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
they should have done, yeah, was take cast photos. They should have just taken the photos if they wanted to say who the characters were, or

SPEAKER 2
just like the script says, every time someone comes up, they say their name; the script is fine. It's not like an elusive script, so that's a really weird choice.

SPEAKER 1
And a lot of the Here Lies Love choices were really, really weird choices. And now I feel like, after this conversation, I can never say anything about that show again. Now it's the fucking antichrist and talking about it makes it stronger. I actually think this production gave this musical life; now this thing will be reproduced. Why? Because the Mark Taper center, center theater group made money off of this play.

SPEAKER 3
They said it was the highest-grossing—really—show of all time. No, really.

SPEAKER 4
So theater's gonna be like, yes, they saw the Broadway production, and they said, We can't do that. We can't produce that huge spectacle.

SPEAKER 3
It closed after three months.

SPEAKER 1
But regionally, they're like, Oh, we can make money. It's this production that will and so forever Filipino actors are gonna have we're

SPEAKER 2
gonna have to do that coffee shop. So it's like, you either have to
(MORE)

SPEAKER 2 (CONT'D)
play in this show about a dictator, or you can go and play a Vietnamese prostitute.

SPEAKER 4
Yeah? I mean, my show exists, but that's it, right? My song selection, musical also feels hard to produce, yeah,

SPEAKER 3
well, we're gonna make it the Filipino other option, yeah, it'll be the Our Town. Yeah, it'll be the Our Town option, yeah, this little Filipino American theater, there's the West Side Story option, that's Here Lies Love, yeah?

SPEAKER 1
I mean, now you know, they're in my performing diversity class, which was about diversity and all the things, including theater. One of my Latina students did a little presentation on West Side Story, and she used our labs' tagging methodology, and she was like, you know, at the end she gave it a score. I don't remember if it was good or bad. She gave—she wrote the blurb. And the whole thing was very confusing, because it was like, there were lots of positives and lots of negatives and everything just kind of seemed to average out. And at the end, I was like, Well, what do you really think of West Side Story, though? I mean, do you hate it? Is it just boring? Is it mediocre? From everything you did with this, I can't even really tell where you landed. And she was like, that's because I hate it. And so does everybody, all Latinos hate it, and we hope it gets produced every season everywhere, and we audition every time, all of us, and we go out really hard for the audition, and we don't care when a West Side Story opens. We're like, great.
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
Now we're all going to audition for that. And I'm like, that's sad, but now we have ours.

SPEAKER 3
We're getting closer to equality.

SPEAKER 1
Welcome to neoliberal America. Every minority gets a shitty, shitty musical that makes a lot of money that every actor from that group wants to audition for every time.

SPEAKER 2
But the thing is, though, that, I mean, some people do love the story, some people like it, but with Miss Saigon it's the same thing where it's like, yeah, I know a lot of people that are like, I would love to do something else, anything, guys, but commit suicide for a white man. Yeah, anything else but that?

SPEAKER 1
Yeah, I know. And that is the story that got every Filipino woman that I know their equity card. I sometimes wonder about Vietnamese American actors, and what they think about Miss Saigon being like a showcase for Filipino Americans. But one time I was, I was in England, you know, I did my one semester abroad in England, and it was so horrible, and there were no Filipino people anywhere. The food, except for South Asian food, is tragic. And I said, I am going to go see some Filipino people right now. And I took the train to London and bought a ticket to masaga. I was like, I'm just going to be in the company of Filipino people. And John, John was the engineer, wow, production. So that was great. But it was weird, because you're like, this actually happened in the Philippines too. It could just be
(MORE)

SPEAKER 1 (CONT'D)
about the Philippines, but instead it's about Vietnamese women. But that's okay, I guess. Is it okay?

SPEAKER 2
I'm not sure, but yeah, I see white men because it's yeah, of course, that's where it all comes back to, yeah.

SPEAKER 1
All right, yeah. I mean, all of these shows we're talking about are strange. They're very odd, and it's odd how much money they make, and people love them, and she kills herself, and then was Saigon, and people are like, I'm crying, I'm like, What is even—what are you doing? Should be angry. You know, the whole audience all the time in these shows, how beautiful.

SPEAKER 2
I told you about the play. Not another truth, not this is not a this is... this is not a truth about Kim from Miss Saigon.

SPEAKER 1
Oh, yeah, yeah, that sounded amazing. Oh my gosh, yeah.

SPEAKER 4
Tell us the background on three historical Asian characters.

SPEAKER 2
What's the Madam Butterfly character's name?

SPEAKER 1
Oh, the one in m butterfly is named. It's named Song. But I don't know if I don't think that's the name in, I think in Puccini, she's just butterfly, oh, but in, but in m butterfly, she is Song lilling, I think, Well, whoever.

SPEAKER 2
I can't remember that name, but the Madame Butterfly, Puccini character. Then there's Kim, and then there's so it's first, just the two of them in the afterlife, well, first, and just one of them.

SPEAKER 1
Oh yeah, first. And they just have to keep reliving their story over and over, of having a baby and then killing themselves and they're living their life: Hold on, I have to have a baby now and then, oh, not to kill myself. And then they discover and then Kim comes along and is doing the same thing. And then they bring in the woman that made the tabloids because they said that she thought the Fargo story was real, and

SPEAKER 2
Searching for the, oh, the Fargo treasure, treasure,

SPEAKER 1
oh, which was a true story. She thought that it says this is a true story. So she believed it. And wow. And she came from Japan, I think, Oh, wow. And, and yeah, and died. But there was a—there's a real story about it

SPEAKER 2
yeah, but there's the real fake story that is, like, she was just this delusional woman, which is not the correct story, but it's all these people trying to maybe deal with their own story as they're having to relive the story that was told about them over and over.

SPEAKER 4
So you learn, you learn later that the reason why we keep seeing it over and over again is that it's a metaphor for how many times that play gets produced. So every time we see their character die, oh,
(MORE)

SPEAKER 4 (CONT'D)
another production is happening. Oh, another production is happening. And it gets to this thing where they're like, We need to stop this. Yeah. We can tell other stories. We can tell our own story. But every time they do, every time they do, it gets reset and, yeah, they relive it over and over again. So it's about trying to reclaim your story and what possibly that looks like, yeah, and in this version, it ends up destroying the book that they're attracted to, yeah, and in the stage directions, it's like, the page is ripped. Every time they go off script, a rip, a rip in the script happens until at the end where they just fully rip up the script. It's never performed again. And they're like, What do we do? And they're like, I guess we write our own story.

SPEAKER 2
So it ends with them writing their own. Okay, where it's so simple and kind of cheesy, but yeah, done in such a beautiful way that we were like, I only want to cry.

SPEAKER 4
I first saw a reading of it in Chicago. Little Black theater reading, nice, no staging, yeah, and the cheers erupted from the audience when they ripped that book open. They told that white man to get out of there. Yeah, it was amazing